Memorandum

Date: January 5, 2015

To: Carole Smith, Superintendent, Portland Public Schools

From: Jason Trombley, Co-Chair, District-wide Boundary Review Advisory Committee (D-BRAC)

CC: Pam Knowles, Chair, Portland Public Schools Board of Education
Ruth Adkins, Co-Chair, Portland Public Schools Board of Education
Judy Brennan, Enrollment Director, Portland Public Schools
Jon Isaacs, Chief of Communications and Public Affairs, Portland Public Schools

Subject: Recommendations regarding acute enrollment issues

D-BRAC has met three times to begin work on the first of two issues charged to us by Superintendent Smith on November 12th, 2014. Those charges were:

1. During the 2014-15 school year, D-BRAC is charged with recommending boundary changes to the Superintendent to relieve acute enrollment issues at the schools identified by PPS with the most critical enrollment problems.
2. Upon resolving acute enrollment issues, D-BRAC should remain intact to begin District-wide Boundary Review and continue to monitor and review boundaries in the future.

At our third D-BRAC meeting on December 11th, the committee took significant time to assess to what extent it could successfully complete Charge #1 at the two schools identified by staff for potential boundary change in 2015: Beverly Cleary K-8 and Chapman K-5.

At this meeting, the committee raised a number of concerns about the feasibility of providing substantive recommendations by the February 1 deadline. These concerns include:

- **Insufficient time** – With only three meetings scheduled before the February deadline, neither the committee nor support staff would have sufficient time to gather and evaluate the needed information to make an informed recommendation and define the impacts of those decisions.
- **Lack of use of Racial Equity Lens to determine Tier 1 schools** – As Board Resolution #4718 calls for a review of school boundaries to better align with the Racial Educational Equity Policy, several committee members raised significant

concern around how the selection of the Beverly Cleary and Chapman campuses align with that policy, given the current demographics of those schools.

- **Lack of a district-wide framework in place to guide short-term decisions**—The committee is eager to develop a framework for future boundary change decisions, but sees significant risk in making decisions now that may be inconsistent with the guidelines that will inform future work.
- **Potential, yet avoidable, damage and prolonged instability for families** – D-BRAC maintains the position that when work begins on the district-wide process, all boundaries will be included in the review. To that end, any short-term boundary change implemented as enrollment relief for the 2015-2016 school year will not be exempt from the district-wide process. Thus, implementing a boundary change now, knowing that the pending district process could amend the short-term action, will cause unneeded and avoidable distress in those communities.

Given these concerns, D-BRAC agreed that it is **not in a position at this time to give advice on boundary changes for Beverly Cleary and Chapman schools.** Instead, it will begin focusing on the district-wide process in January 2015. D-BRAC also agreed that staff should continue working to identify appropriate short-term remedies for schools experiencing both under-enrollment and overcrowding in advance of the district-wide process.

D-BRAC understands that the Superintendent and School Board could choose to continue pursuing a 2015 boundary change for Beverly Cleary and Chapman. Please be aware of the potential consequences of that decision:

- Additional instability and uncertainty for families over the next two years, consistent with the points noted above;
- Undermining the credibility of D-BRAC before the committee begins its work.

D-BRAC remains committed to developing a stable, equitable and community-supported process for addressing enrollment issues in our growing school district. Please let me know if you have any questions.